

My Late Father's Correspondence



PEN BEAUTIFUL LETTERS IN YOUR REGENCY STORY

BY HAYLEY GORDON

ONCE the mourners had left, St George on the Hill was quiet once more. The wind that frequented the grassy slope touched each of its beloved gravestones in turn, ending on the newest arrival. It touched, too, the figure of a woman who had remained beyond the rest for just a moment longer. Her eyes traced the rote words written on the gravestone: In memory of Thomas Lockley, who died Nov 7th, 1832. "Rest in peace, papa", she thought, "if you know how."



My Late Father's Correspondence

A READ & REPLY GAME



STORYBREWERS
ROLEPLAYING

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My Late Father's Correspondence

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Letters handwritten by Vee Hendro.

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HOW TO PLAY

WELCOME TO *My Late Father's Correspondence*, a read and reply epistolary game about grief, family and identity. This double page spread, and the one following, contain everything you need to know to start playing the game and experience its story.

CONTENT NOTICE

This game includes content relating to grief, patriarchy, illness, colonialism, war and death.

This game takes place over nine days, spread across three months. On each day, you will receive a number of letters that bring unfolding news and events. Read all the letters for each day, then answer them in the order you think best. You can reply to the comments and questions in the letter, but you can also discuss other thoughts and feelings, and include details of your imagined everyday life. Once you've finished writing, give the letters to a footman to put in the post. When you're ready, perhaps after a well deserved break, turn to the next day of play.

Each day of letters you encounter has been carefully handwritten. If you enjoy writing by hand, you can grab your fountain pen and create your own physical letters as a memento of your experience.

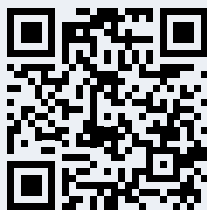
Do not read ahead, as the game is intended to be experienced one day at a time. We also recommend you play each day of letters on a separate day of your own life, this way you can experience the story slowly unfolding. If you're ever looking for a particular day or letter to refer to, there's a spoiler-free index at the back of this book on page 96.

Once you have finished the story, you might choose to play the two-player variant. In this version, one player takes on the role of the central character, while the second player—ideally someone who has already played the game solo—becomes the Postmaster. The Postmaster's role is to read the central character's letters and use them to modify or add to the correspondence for each day. This is a fun and collaborative way to play. A full Postmaster's Guide is included on pages 74–93. It contains spoilers so only read it after you've played.

My Late Father's Correspondence is a bittersweet family drama, contemplative in tone and at times quietly tragic. It is rooted in the struggles of living day to day, and you won't find any murder-mysteries or occult secrets contained within. Lean into your emotions and write with your heart.

CURSIVE AND PLAIN TEXT

THIS GAME MAKES USE OF handwritten letters in cursive roundhand. While evocative and fun, it can be a little difficult to read! Start with the cursive version of the game, but if you have any trouble reading it, you can refer to the plain text version. Use the QR code below to quickly access the plain text.



bit.ly/MLFCplaintext

BACKGROUND MUSIC

WE HAVE COMPILED a period appropriate playlist if you would like to listen to some background music while you write. Each day has its own set of songs, or you can listen to the playlist in full.



bit.ly/mylatefathersmusic

HISTORICAL NOTES

WATCH OUR VIDEO SERIES to discover the historical details behind several key letters and learn what they reveal about the people who wrote them. This isn't part of the game, but is a fun way to discover some of the historical underpinnings behind its story. Beware, spoilers abound, so play each day before you watch the corresponding video.



bit.ly/mylatefathersvideos

Day 1

Day 4

Day 7



A sprig of lavender with several small, light purple flowers is positioned in the upper left corner of the page. The background is a dark, textured wooden surface.

Nov 29th, 1832.

Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire, England.

Your name is Agatha Lockley. You are the younger child of the retired Col. Thomas Lockley. You are yet unmarried, and live in your childhood and ancestral home, Eadly Hall. Your father passed away in that very home three weeks ago. You do not stand to inherit it.

Your father's funeral has come and gone. Now, you are the only one in residence at Eadly Hall.

That is all you need to know for now—the rest is for you to discover and imagine.

A sprig of dried lavender flowers is positioned in the top right corner of the page, extending diagonally across the dark brown background.

*My
Late Father's
Correspondence*



DAY 1

Nov 29, 1832

I have not been into father's study since he passed. His reading glasses are still perched on the edge of the small mahogany desk, as if he had just taken them off to rub the bridge of his nose before asking me to hand him the next of his letters. Though his study has not become mine, his letters have. I had best see what my aunt has written me.

1A, P.9

T.P.
Piccadilly

Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milcot
Gloucestershire

Paid 8

London, Nov 28th 1832.

My darling Aggie,

I hope the days after the funeral weren't too trying. It is one thing to face the endless stream of condolences about your father's death when you have your dearest aunt by your side, but it's quite another thing to be left in that big great house all by yourself.

I write with tragic news, I am to be delayed in London. With your older brother Nicholas so long away, and thus absconded from all duties and responsibilities, the business of executing your father's estate is far more of a mess than I could have imagined. I have, of course, written to his last address and the one before that, as no doubt have you - I am not however too hopeful he will suddenly appear in London in readiness for the responsibilities of inheritance. Nevertheless, I am duty-bound to do all I can to find him before anything else can be resolved, so I am doing what I must.

In the meantime, you shall have to see to the running of the estate and handle the barrages of the many well-wishers. These are both tasks I know you are most capable of, but are tiresome nevertheless. Perhaps most tedious of all, it's imperative that you open and reply to all the various correspondences that will now come flooding in — those for yourself, and most especially, those addressed to your father.

Your butler, Mr. Alder will bring the letters to you each morning — take them, and let them rest on your desk for just a moment. Take a breath, and then when you are ready, read and reply to each. It is crucial that you reply to all correspondence on the day of its arrival, as at this important

time matters are best taken care of swiftly. You hardly need me to tell you this, but be considered in your response as there are delicate matters afoot.

My dear, you know people will say all kinds of things in their letters - of you and your father both. You'll do well to remember that is merely their opinion, and take it with a grain of salt. It is all too common people misremember, or their prejudices come to the forefront. Except for me of course, I am your favourite aunt and therefore right about everything!

I know you and your father did not always see eye to eye. He could be a difficult man in his own way. But we all have our moods, and he loved you through each and every one of them that overtook him. At any rate, some of his

acquaintances shall be vital to your place in society now he is gone. Especially as you are 23 and yet unmarried you may find yourself calling on them for favours in the future. Not that now is a time to think about such things — heavens, you are in mourning!

Look after yourself my dearest, keep well, and I shall be back as soon as I can — heaven-willing with your brother in tow, but heaven may indeed not will it! Write to me now even if briefly and do assure me you are well.

Your loving aunt,
Gertrude Allington

DAY 2

Nov 31, 1832

The circulars, military journals, and nature periodicals are still piling up. I must see to that before the desk is lost entirely. Aunt has paid the mail charge again which is kind of her, though it really ought to be left for Eadly.

2A, P.14

Nicholas and Agatha Lockley

Eadly Hall

Milcot

Habershire



Add:
 $\frac{1}{2}$

$\frac{1}{2}$

2B, P.18

T-P
Piccadilly

Paid 8x2

Agatha Lockley

Eadly Hall

Milcot

Habershire

Glasgow, Nov 27th 1832.

My dear Sir and Madam,

I wager you do not remember me, though I certainly remember you both!

The last time we met Nicholas was a tiny boy of six quite obsessed with painting everything and Miss Agatha, you were a plump, bright thing of the age of three - and very charming, I assure you.

I write with a heavy heart to hear news of your father's passing. I count myself among your father's oldest friends from his time in service. I knew him before he was even made a cornet, and I consider myself to have the privilege of knowing him inside and out.

You may not know this, but when we first met your father had joined my unit of dragoons as a "gentleman volunteer" - that's what they called them back then - men

from good families too poor to buy their first commission, waiting to be given one by merit or connections. Even then, he had a way of devoting himself to those around him that was admirable.

You have no doubt heard the story of how he received his first commission, and the unfortunate French captain who mistook him for a member of his own side after the cavalry's uniform changed. The story of how he received his promotion to Captain was less glamorous - he simply worked hard until his turn arrived - but in many ways it was more characteristic of him.

Despite what others say, I do not think your father loved war in the way everyone seems to suppose. He certainly drew satisfaction from a well-executed

manoeuvre, and he was renowned as a very skillful leader, but I do not think he loved it. Rather, I believe he felt at home there, in the small world of his regiment, where he was in a way a sort of father to the boys around him. He said to me once "they're good lads" and the way he said it betrayed a fondness more keen than the simple assessment of one's troops. Every loss at the Battle of Morales was hard for him I know, but he certainly inflicted far more back at the French.

But I have gone on too long for a letter of condolences. I hope the both of you are faring as well as expected.

and are keeping on as your father would have wanted. I remember his face on the day Nicholas was born. He looked like a man struck by the discovery of a duty more grand than any he thought possible. He was a good, dear friend, and if I might assist his lovely children it would be my honour.

I remain,
Your faithfully,

Maj. Gen. John Weatherston
2nd Dragoon Guards

London, Nov 30th 1832.

My dearest Aggie,

You are ever reliable my darling!
But please do take care of yourself as well
as you do the estate.

You will never guess who I have run into
here in London - young Mr. Rajiv Hughes,
the ward of your father's friend. You would
not have seen him since he left to study
in Oxford. Do you remember he used
to visit every summer when you and
Nicholas were younger? He never got on
well with Nicholas, but you two were
practically inseparable. We all recall
the time you put on that little play
together - what was it called?

Mr. Hughes is returning to
Hampshire and offered to call on you
and keep you company. I think it

proper since he is an old family friend,
and of course Mr. Alder will be there.
Should I tell him to come, or would
you like me to ask him to write first?

As well as that, there is need
to handle some of your father's effects
from his rented London residence. In
Nicholas' absence, I think you are best
placed to decide what to do with each.
The lawyers said we can have each effect
sent to Eadly Hall,
stored here in London,
donated to charity, or
destroyed as appropriate.

Tell me know your wishes as regard
to each.

Your loving aunt,
Gertrude Allington

A FURTHER LETTER IS ENCLOSED, P.20



BLACKSTONE & ASSOCIATES

Dear Sir or Madam,

London, Nov 29th 1822

Please advise on the disposal of the following effects found at the London residence of Thomas Lockley:

Jewellery. Silver cravat pin with pearl inlaid, gold plated cravat pin, cufflinks with painted peacock, cufflinks with painted gardenias, shirt studs.

A woman's ring inlaid with amethyst and freshwater pearl engraved interior T. L. O. L.
A necklace of cut steel and paste gems in a case labelled 'Kennell' with a purple ribbon around it.

Portrait. Half-length, 44 x 34 in.
A woman in her early twenties with dark hair, green eyes holds a baby boy to her chest. Plaque reads Olivia Lockley, as commissioned by Thomas Lockley and painted by Augustus Glenford, 1806.

Clothes. Shirts, cravats, coats, vests, pants, shoes and two top hats.

Papers. A small number of letters to and from various doctors in London. Many loose pages (perhaps intended as a journal?) accounts of various

Your father's taste was a little out of date, although in my view still quite acceptable for a man his age and position.

here, nice somewhere

Your mother looks so happy I hope you will hang it



BLACKSTONE & ASSOCIATES

bottles, accounts of various birds desc. and locations where said birds were seen, their colouring. A bill for one necklace from Funnell & Co. dated last month.

Port. Many ordinary bottles such as could be purchased at any store. Three with faded labels that are likely of value

Cockburn 1812, Sandeman 1866

Yeatman 1792.

Figurines. Painted cavalry figures.

Medals. Waterloo medal 1815, Long Service medal, Badge of the 18th Royal Hussars.

Locket. Silver, half a palm in length, attached to a chain. Inside is pictured a woman in her 40s, brown hair, eyes staring straight at the viewer. Signed with painter's name & year. George Cooper, 1828.

Do you know who this is? I've no idea.

One reads Lt. Col. George Hughes. One is of himself—it's quite a good likeness.

The most impressive, kept in London for events no doubt. The next are in his room in Eadly. He never liked to talk about the stories behind them.

Some father's regiment, the 18th Royal Hussars. The painted meticulously on the bottom bases. I found the names of some of his military friends.



BLACKSTONE & ASSOCIATES

Bird Statues. Many,
difficult to transport.
Three most notable:

Peacock - carved wood,
half life-sized, ornately painted.

Honey buzzard - stone
2ft in height, 4ft in wingspan
unpainted.

Bluetthroat - carved wood,
3 in height, painted in
exacting detail.

We have the honour to be,
Your most obedient servants,

James F. Stuart
BLACKSTONE & ASSOCIATES

DAY 3

Dec. 5, 1832

No matter how much this room is aired, it continues to smell of paint and old tobacco. Opening father's mail still leaves me with a trace of unease, like a child who has snuck their hand into Cook's pastries before they are served.

3A, P.24

~~ADMA~~



*Col. Thomas Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milecott
Hampshire*

3B, P.27

**T·P
Piccadilly**

Paid 8

*Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milecott
Hampshire*

Rome, Nov 20. 1832.

My dear Sir,

Here are his latest ~~show~~ of expenses. Do you wish me to arrange payment as usual? For such a prudent man you have truly raised an extravagant son.

I don't know why you continue paying for him - let the boy fend for himself for a month or two and he'll certainly understand the meaning of responsibility. I've ~~been~~ been telling you for years you are too soft on him, and this is where it has ended. Can you imagine what he will be like as master of Eadly Hall?

I've no concept what your girl is up to, but I hope it is a bit more appropriate. You may complain she is too sensitive, ~~but~~ but which would you prefer?

If you're worried about your health then come here. The continental life and colour will do you good and you can wrangle your son yourself.

you know how much Olivia loved it here and in Florence also - before the war took hold atleast. You two always looked so inescapably english, no matter how hard you tried!

Although if you ask me it is retirement that is the real trouble. You never were happier than when you had something to do.

Something real to do not just the dull business of a gentleman ridding off while his Steward manages his estate.

At any rate I have given you my counsel and I'm sure you will ignore it as usual.

Your friend,

Matthew Summer



Look at all this!
Totals £120 for just
three months!!

Sept. 9

Palazzo Jimi feroni
Locanda delle Armi d'Ingleterra
Tour Galleria dell' Accademia

Sept 11

Paints and Canvas 34 shillings
Grand Hotel de New York
Sartoria Vanni - 3 suits, boots.

Sept 13

Locanda della Rossa
Trattoria Buzzini
Uffizi Gallery
Canvas 4 shillings

Sept 14

Locanda della Rossa
Sartoria A. Caraceni
Boboli Gardens
Palazzo Belle Donne

Sept-Nov

Long term lease of
residence on via
Federuci Tassi

London, Dec 2nd 1832.

My dearest Aggie,

It has been done as you have described, those of your father's effects you wished sent to Eadly you will find arrived with this letter. As I was looking through his papers I found this letter from Nicholas. I've enclosed it in case it is helpful in tracking him down. However, it seems to be one of his old return addresses.

As for me, I am counting down the days until I can return to Haversham. As executor of your father's will, I am sadly stuck here in London until all reasonable

attempts have been made to find your brother. At that point, I am told we can seek an order from the court to have your father's will resolved as if your brother himself was dead (quite shocking, I hope it doesn't come to that).

In the meantime, darling, it brings me much comfort to know you shall have company from Captain Rajiv Hughes, as I have now heard he is. He told me he intends to be in Haversham within the next two weeks. He has been away rather a long time, perhaps you can show him what's changed (if anything has changed, you

know Havershire!') Col. Hughes has
passed, I'm sad to say, and as
he had no natural children,
Captain Hughes inherited his Havershire
estate. Yet he told me he hasn't
been there since he was twelve!
It will be strange for him I am sure.

Yours affectionately,

Gertrude Allington

being burdened with guilt.
ing. We'll do it anyway, so there's no sense
at's her happiness is made whatever you might
we better ought to do what we want better

3B+

Grand Hotel de New York
Via' Arno Corsini
Firenze

END OF DAY 3

DAY 4

Dec. 9, 1832

How strange it was to have Alder press a note from the staff into my hands this morning—he said he would be kindly obliged were I to read it. How quickly he departed once I had taken it.

4A, P.32

Mdm for your kind attention

4B, P.33

T.P.
Lombard St

Paid 8

Agatha Lockley
Essex Hall
Milbot
Wiltshire

Dear Madam,

With Col. Lockley no longer with us (bless his soul), myself and Mr. Alder would like to know whether you'd like to make any changes to the day to day running of the house? As you would recall, Col. Lockley had some requirements around the dosing of curtains, timing of meals, and other matters that may no longer suit you. We've known you many years Madam, and we all wish you to be as comfortable as possible in these difficult times, so please don't hesitate to ask us.

We also wanted to ask about the menu for the week. As you requested we have dispensed with formal dinners when there's no guests, since there's just yourself about. We did wonder what you might like instead. Mary told us you'd not asked for anything cooked the last few nights. Is there anything you'd find suitable? Gammy's into the village every day now with all the mail back and forth, so he can pick you up anything you wish. Mrs. Preston does a great lamb roast - she's not made it because Col. Lockley did not enjoy lamb - but perhaps you might like to try it. Also we've heard there might be guests afoot? We remain Madam,

Yr most obt servants,

E. Stuart and M. Alder

London

Dec 8th 1832.

Dear Miss Lockley,

Your aunt told me that I might call upon you when I return to Flabershire next week. It will be a delight to restore our old acquaintance after so many years.

Your aunt has said you are short on good company, and I in truth I am the same, especially with Christmas so close approaching. It is my first return to Flabershire since my guardian's death in India (Col.

Hughes — a friend of your father's. Do you remember him?) Now I've reached the age of majority, I have inherited Caldwell House. It is currently being opened on my account. I intend to live in it, at least for a while until I am called back into service. It will be

strange to be back there without him after all these years.

If visiting you alone was not too much of an imposition, I must admit that I asked your aunt if I might see your father's collection of military figures. She kindly obliged. I found seeing them quite moving in a way. Did you know he had painted his own regiment, the 18th Royal Hussars? I knew them instantly when I saw them. The Royal Hussars are easily recognized for their uniforms—dark blue with yellow braiding. He had painted my father too. If you do not have other plans for it, perhaps I might give that particular figurine a home in Caldwell House?

I'm not sure if he told you, but your father came to

see me after my guardian passed away — this was in London three years ago, shortly before I left for Gibraltar. He gave me his condolences, but he also left me his advice, of sorts.

He said that military men grow callous of death, but to do so was to doom one's judgement.

The way to be a good officer was to feel each death acutely, yet act on none individually. That, he said, is how to excel — and yet, he added, it leaves a bitter taste in your mouth to do so, a sort of taste that lingers with you long after retirement. Strange advice.

I think. Fortunately, none of the men under my command have suffered further than a broken leg!

But enough of those passed onwards for now. You must tell me something of yourself, though no

Doubt I will find out much more when I visit. I remember well our little games and stories with much fondness. I still write poetry I must admit, although it is quite as awful as it was back then! A lot of our adventures blur as childhood memories do, but I have a strange one that comes back to me. I insisted we dress as hideous ghosts to try to get Nicholas to atone for a crime of having painted your toy horse a horrible red (?) colour — he was not scared but we did terrify Mrs. Stuart. Is she still with you? I suppose I will also have to think further about household staff myself.

At any rate, I will see you shortly. I will bring a marvellous ginger cake I have become far too fond of in London. We shall talk more then. Yours sincerely,

Capt. Basil Hughes

DAY 5

Dec. 12, 1832

How odd that a letter should be hand delivered by footman all the way from London. It has been scented with perfume—jasmine? Alder told me the footman was most reluctant to hand it over to anyone but my father—of course the impossibility of that eventually convinced him to do otherwise. He waits downstairs now for my reply.

5A, P.38

Thomas Lockley

5B, P.40

*Agatha Lockley,
Cadley Hall
Mileot
Hampshire*





My Darling Thomas,

I won't argue with you about it any more. With your state being what it is, can you really expect me to stay in London while only the Lord knows what's happening to you in Milhot? What if things worsen? What if something were to happen to you while I am not there? I could not bear such a thing.

No, I am packing, and I will be there within a week. I have a distant cousin I can claim to be visiting. I'm sure scrutiny in the countryside cannot be as dreadful as you've imagined. At any rate, even if we must pretend to be distant acquaintances I should have the good fortune of looking into your eyes once more.

Stop worrying about what will happen if I come, and start to think about the good you will experience from my being there! Surely I shall be



the best balm for body and soul one could hope for, quite above what any doctor has recommended you. And heavens, don't worry yourself about your daughter finding out, I'm sure she has better things to do with her time than spy on her father.

Shouldn't she be looking for a match by now? Perhaps you ought to send her to London for the rest of the season - then we should be undisturbed.

I've sent up Matthias should you wish to send me word back about anything before I depart. Don't try to change my mind you won't succeed.

I love you darling.

I shall be with you before long.



Habershire,
Dec 8th 1832.

Dear Sir and Madam,

We write with great condolences upon the passing of your father, ~~we~~ who was one of the biggest supporters of the Habershire Birdwatching Association. We thank your family for his generous bequest of £100. As an expression of thanks for his significant contribution to the Association in life and beyond it, we wish to invite you to be the guests of honour at the annual holiday season gala of the Association on 18th December. It would be our pleasure to have you attend. I look forward to hearing your response.

Yours Faithfully,
Sarah Williams

ANNUAL GALA

"As, birds, our wishes fly."

THE Company of

*r/s Nicholas and Apollonia
Lodley and guests*

IS REQUESTED TO ATTEND THE
Habershire Birdwatching Association Ball
AT Capt. BARTON'S HALL on TUESDAY,
18TH of Dec current, at 5 o'clock P.M.

Habershire, Dec, 1832.



S. WILLIAMS
Z. LOVALL
H. WARREN } Managers.

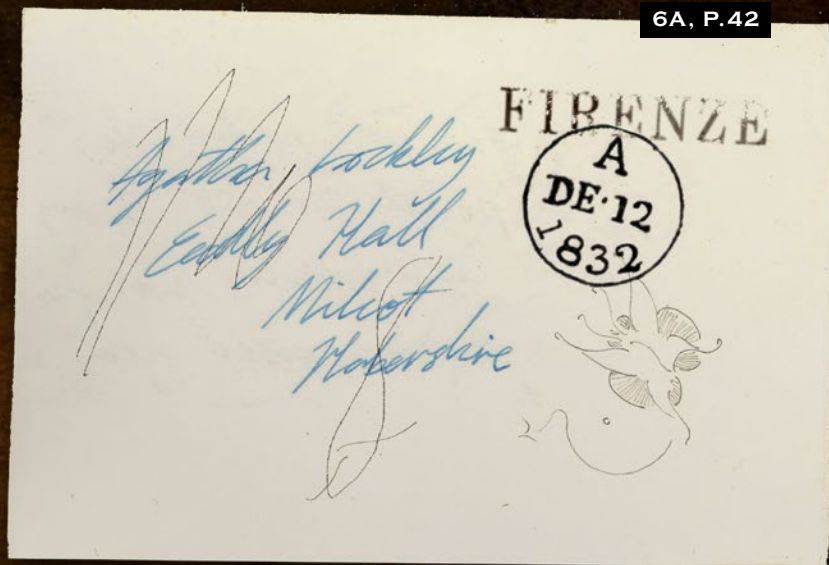
END OF DAY 5

DAY 6

Dec. 19, 1832

An unpaid letter sent all the way from Florence. I would recognise that hand anywhere, and most especially when it has scrawled my own name. Perhaps a glass of claret before I open this one.

6A, P.42



Flourice Dec 9. 1892

6A

My dear sister,

I'd gone to pick up father's money order from the post office, and instead I received a letter from Mr Summers saying that father had passed away. I am quite shocked in truth. I didn't even know that his illness had taken a turn for the worst. I suppose that is my own fault, but you know what it was like when I wrote him — nothing but nonsense about responsibility and the estate and not a word about his actual life.

I suppose you might tell me of the state of things. Mr Summers was very vague on the details. Did father keep me in his will or did he do what he threatened to do before I left and truly disinherit me? At any rate, I thought you might ask our aunt to send some funds to tide me over? It's an odd awkward situation, you being at ~~the~~ Eadly and

or ~~more~~ being here with little idea what is happening back there.

I've not a great want to return to Eadly to deal with it all. Not only would it take me a week or two to get there from Florence (I'm in Florence now,) and a great deal of expense might I add, but I've just taken up a proper rental here which would have to be dealt with, and there's all my paintings and supplies to think about. Besides, if you know with all those relatives visiting who disapprove of me, you don't want me around anyway.

The truth is Aggie, I've met someone. Someone born here in Florence. It's funny, they barely spoke a word of English when we met and my Italian was certainly in dire need of improvement, and yet a connection was there. A connection

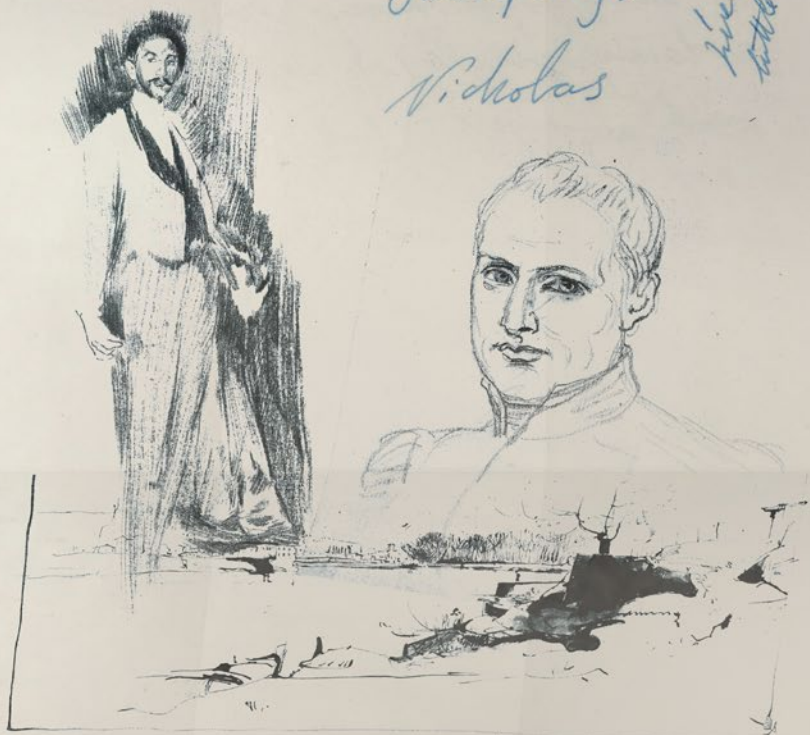
was instantly there and I knew it and felt from the first moment. They're a great painter in their own right too. I am learning from them with every day that passes, I ~~feel~~ feel my mind expanding and my abilities growing - it is the ~~most~~ missing piece of the puzzle I've been looking for. I don't want to leave it all, ~~now~~ not now anyway.

Aggie, I know you might have felt like you got the rotten lot where Father is concerned. You know Father and I did not exactly get along, and sometimes you were certainly caught up in the middle of that, which I regret. But you were always so good at managing the estate, and managing him if you needed to, there hardly seems a point in my being there to step in and antagonise him further. At any rate ~~so~~, he is passed now, and it is time for us to live our own lives as we will.

How are you keeping anyway? Are
 married yet yourself? Did father find
 a nice army boy? I hope things
 tolerable there and not as dire as
 all sounds.

Your brother
 Faithfully,
 Nicholas

I've drawn you a
 little of my life



DAY 7

Dec. 21, 1832

After more than a month, the key has been found to the locked drawer of father's desk. There was nothing inside but Nicholas' old return addresses and a locket portrait of mama. The locket is scratched and part of it is bent. I think it is the same one he took when he was posted in France. I'll place it by my inkwell—mama can watch over me while I answer today's correspondence.

7A, P.47

*Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall*

7B, P.50

**T·P
Piccadilly**

*Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Wiltot
Gloucestershire*

Paid 8



Dear Madam,

I thank you for the courtesy of replying to my prior letter, my footman shall await your next one. Having now been made aware of your father's passing, it grieves me greatly. I shall be travelling to St. George on the hill to visit his grave and say my goodbyes.

I do believe you are in possession of my locket, if you would be so kind to give it to my footman. I feel honesty demands me tell you that I intend to leave it at your father's grave, but do not fear, I will do so in a way that ensures it cannot be seen.

As for what you might imagine passed between your father and myself, if it will aggrive you in any way, then I assure you nothing happened and I bid you cease to read my letter here.

Otherwise read on at your own peril.

Your father and I met by chance in Vauxhall gardens, where I had gone to try to and recover some feeling of joy in my life after my husband's passing. I saw him strolling some several yards away behind the friends he was with - they were taken up with conversation but he was a watcher of the world. I introduced myself, quite a rude thing to do, I suppose, and we walked some way together. I found him to be solemn but charming, I enjoyed the depth of emotion I saw within him, a contrast from the many shallow men life has seen fit to offer me.

We continued our acquaintance at several cafés, the theatre (which he did not enjoy), the concert hall (which he did), and then eventually we continued our acquaintance in a different way.

I have never known a man so thoughtful as your father in the right company. When we met he was watching me, always aiming to understand my intentions, determine my needs.

He liked to be alone when the mood struck him and I respect that. But when he was with me he made me feel as if he listened to my conversation for it's own sake, and for no reason but that. It was a feeling that is too rare to find in this world.

At one point we considered marriage, but we were quite happy as we were.

Free from the trappings and conventions it would put upon us.

As I said, thank you for the courtesy you have shown me in replying. Given the nature of the connection between us, I think it's best I do not reveal my true name, but allow me to sign off with the respect two women owe one another. I learned much about you and your brother from your father.

He spoke of you with great fondness, if with a sense of ignorance about your true thoughts and intentions in life. He said there was much about you that reminded him of your mother.

I hope that is something you wish to hear.

London, Dec 20th 1832.

My darling Aggie,

You will not believe what has happened! I have heard from Nicholas! He said that he received my letters all at once, having finally visited the post office to check for correspondence from the family sent to his old residences. He gave me his current address.

Nicholas said he may return to Eadly at some point in the future, but has asked me to remit the funds from the will into his account in the interim. Technically that is possible, the lawyers could arrange it, but I'd rather he ~~is~~ come back, see to the care of the estate, and have things

done properly. Still I am truly most sensitive to your needs in this situation - what would you prefer I do? I can delay the transfer of the funds for a few weeks if you would like, after that I am bound by law to make the transfer. At least once the transfer has been made I can return to Flabershire to keep you company!

Once the transfer of the funds is complete, your allowance will be dependent on Nicholas, though it would be a very uncharitable thing should he decide to alter it in any way. You do have a dowry provided in the will.

It is £4000, which is equal to some £160 a year, a well enough amount to satisfy, say, an army gentleman of £1000 a year (not that I am thinking of Capt. Hughes! Although since I am on the topic, how are you finding him?).

Still, I think one way or another things will surely be resolved, and that at least gives me some peace.

But on to cheerier topics, the Flakeshire Christmas Ball awaits in just a few days! How are your preparations? You have certainly

been in mourning long enough for
it to be ~~per~~ perfectly acceptable
for you to add some silks and
trimmings to your black attire.

I do hope you will be able to
have some fun, truly you deserve some
my dear.

Yours with great affection,
Gertrude Allington

DAY 8

Jan 3, 1833

What does one do with reams and reams of old papers? All the important documents are already in the custody of solicitors. What remains in here is boxes of letters, receipts, reminders, annotated periodicals, and the occasional note to himself. A lifetime of thoughts carefully filed one day at a time.

8A, P.55



Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milton
Wiltshire



8B, P.57

Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milton
Wiltshire

Florence Dec 20th 1832.

My dear sister,

Merry Christmas, or so it will have been by the time this reaches you. Since your last letter I've been thinking a lot about things with you, and Eadly Hall. Aunt Gertrude has also written me, so now I'm fully appraised of the situation.

Here are things as they stand. While I do intend to claim my inheritance, I'm not well positioned to live in Eadly Hall, either in practicalities or in temperament. Truthfully, I am also aware that my current companion is ill-suited to accompanying me back home. You know how the English can be terribly prudish about so many things.

With all this in mind, I want you to know I intend to stay in Florence, if I can anyhow. You are so good at managing the estate so I had thought maybe things could simply keep on going as they are—until you get married of course. I imagine that might be some relief for you. to know nothing need change at Eadly Hall?

As to the matter of Eadly's expenses, Aunt knows the details of the accounts, you can simply arrange it with her. Send any paperwork to Mr. Summers and I shall sign it from here. Everything shall go along quite swimmingly.

I do intend to send for father's bird statues though, should they still be in our possession. I'd like to think of them as his artistic side. I might even imagine myself as an ornately carved heron. Perhaps some day I will finally break free from the thick stone that encases our family and take flight. One day I would like it if you should come to visit me here - but not too soon I imagine as there must be still quite a bit that needs tending to. In the meantime, I promise I shall write.

Your beloved brother,
Nicholas



Hampshire

Jan 2, 1833.

Dear Miss Lockley,

I thank you for your kindness in hosting me at Eady Hall on the new year! It was quite a relief not to spend it alone at Caldwell House.

We had both endured years greatly lacking in merriment, I am glad that together we seemed to find it in its final hours.

Seeing you at Eady inspired within me a strange sense of displaced nostalgia. It is the same house in which you and I played so often many years ago, yet our place within it has changed.

I recall my guardian and your father sitting in the very seats we sat, trimming cigars and drinking port.

At the time I thought them the very pinnacle of what men could be—

sons in their youth always think such things about their fathers. I cannot recall what they talked about, but I am sure it was very different to the sentiments we shared over ginger cake and claret.

As you know, I became the ward of Col. Hughes when I was but three years old. When the world looked at us, they always assumed a distance between us. I was his ward, not his son, not a part of his real family. They thought, I imagined that I could not truly know him, and he could not truly care for me. Yet to me, he was everything a father might be and more. He not only gave me guidance and opportunity, but a great affection that grounded me through any hardships life saw fit to offer.

The greatest compliment he ever gave me was to say I had grown very like him, and I still find myself considering what actions he would take, whether as a Captain or even as a man.

I hope I do not presume too much when I observe that the situation between you and your father was very different. I remember when we were children, everyone used to say that Nicholas took after your mother, and you took after your father. When you both would spend far too long at carnival games trying to win, or when you both woke up early to see the world gently wake, everyone would say you were truly cut from the same cloth. Yet from what I have learned from you, it seems that you became very different people as time went on. I know you laboured deeply

under your fathers expectations. I wonder how you will consider his stories and advice now that you are no longer bound to follow it.

It is snowing again, yet I find the weather more inviting than hostile. Perhaps the part of me that wishes to have little adventures has been reawakened. If you do not object, I should like to continue to call on you. I hope to be in Haversham for some months before I must again depart for service.

Yours faithfully,
Capt. Rajiv Hughes

DAY 9

Jan 6, 1833

Almost two months of mail and I have finally seen fit to leave my own letter writing set permanently on top of father's mahogany desk. I need not move it for anyone it seems. Not for a long time.

9A, P.62

Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Wilcot
Hampshire

T.P.
Piccadilly

Paid 8

9B, P.64

Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Wilcot
Hampshire

BIRMINGHAM
JA3
1833
G

London, Jan 5th 1833.

Darling Aggie,

It is finally done. Ownership and funds have been transferred, paperwork has been signed, countersigned, and then signed again, and my duties as executor of your father's estate have come to an end. I shall be returning home to Haversham within the week, and I shall be glad to see it, and of course, you! It is well we can put this behind us, grieve our grieving, and look towards a brighter day.

You have been exceptional in the management of the estate, and it seems little is to change in that regard - does such a thought make you feel lighter or heavier?

Of course you will have me nearby, and I hope I can ease the burden somewhat.

There was a parade of Hussars today in London (the Prince's own I think) that made me think of your father. I remember the first time he put on that blue uniform, that ridiculous uniform with the yellow braids, he seemed instantly at home in it, and you couldn't help but think him capable of great things. Yet, and this perhaps is a foolish thing only a woman would say, greatness ought to begin with a great love for one's family. I believe he had such a love, I will always be a little sad that he could never quite show it. But let's turn to happier topics. What news from Haversham?

With love, and anticipation of my return,
Gertrude Allington

Birmingham, Jan 3rd 1833.

Dear Madam,

My condolences on the passing of your father. Shortly before his passing he commissioned me to paint a portrait of himself for the gallery at Eadly Hall. He said the portrait there now is of him as a young man, and he should like it to show a face that has been through life instead.

The commission fee for the work has been paid upfront, and I had already met with him three times some

months ago to take sketches, though until now I had been busy with other work.

I am writing to you to seek instructions as to how you would like your father portrayed in this portrait. He did not leave me any instructions in that regard, and although I had some starting sense of his character and bearing, it is always best to ask family in such cases. What particular characteristics, moods, achievements, or interests would you like me to include?

As well as that, there is also the possibility of my adding other family members to the painting, if it is

something you would like — although your father will remain the key subject.

As strange as it sounds, I have several times painted family portraits in memoriam. In such portraits, people need not be portrayed as they are, but rather as they would like to be remembered.

This is not the first time I have had the honour to paint your family. Many years ago, almost 30 years ago now, your father also commissioned me to paint your mother. She had some natural aptitude for painting herself and was very curious about my process. I even gave her some lessons around that time. I remember her very fondly.

Let me know how I should
proceed, and how I might best
portray your father.

Yours sincerely,

Augustus G. Penford.

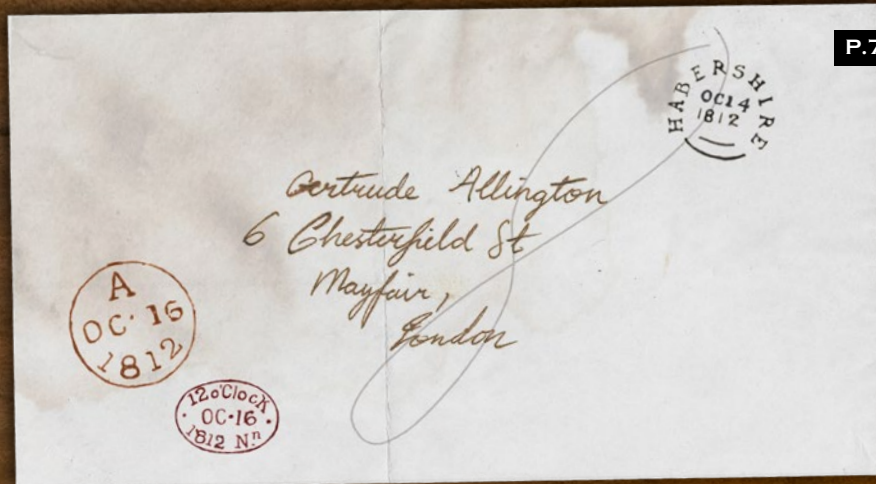
EPILOGUE

Apr 28, 1833

I received the portrait from Mr Glenford today. He came all the way from Birmingham to deliver it. Together we hung it in the gallery ourselves. We took tea and he entertained me with stories of some of the most eccentric characters he had painted, of which my father was not one.

When he had left, I returned to the gallery to take the portrait in once more. This would be it—the final version of him to look upon from this day forth. Mr Glenford reflected what I had asked most exactly, but was I right in what I asked for?

As I contemplated this question, I found myself idly leafing through some of the old documents my aunt had sent over. I shall have to sort them at some point, but as she said, all are old, none are urgent. Between receipts and reminders, invoices and lists of errands, I stumbled across an old letter, and was surprised to find a familiar handwriting that lingered on the edge of my memory. This letter was written by my mother...



Although she cannot receive it, perhaps I shall write one more letter in reply before I give my writing desk a much needed reprieve.



Habershire, Oct 14. 1812

My dearest Gertrude,

I hope you and the children are having a wonderful time in London! I've written a little letter for them which I have enclosed within - I know I could have simply written a postscript, but there was something delightful about sending them proper mail (complete with one of Thomas' silly wax seals) so that they might, at ages two and six, finally know the joy of correspondence. I cannot say I credit your claim that you miss the company of such small creatures now your William is gone away to school, but I know Agatha and Nicholas will appreciate their adventures in town.

Sadly, however, your efforts to orchestrate some alone time for Thomas and myself did not bear fruit, as one day after the children left his unit was called to the Iberian Peninsula.

by Col. Weatherdon. I did honour your ambitions by taking tea in the gallery with his portrait, which, painted as it was when he inherited Eadly at twenty-two, is quite out of date.

I have now been four days alone at Eadly and the experience has been overwhelmingly strange. I keep imagining I hear Nicholas' little footsteps scurrying down to the kitchen in search of leftover cake (he has no concept that I know of his night-time activities!), or Agatha's little sighs when the largest cup in her cup collection will not fit inside the smallest one. Thomas is too irregularly present for me to imagine him, but I miss him nevertheless.

On the first day of my solitude I was very busy indeed, and achieved more in the way of organising, rearranging, and

accounting than I had in the entire month prior. On the second day I had done it all, all of it, everything, and so after a walk to Milcot town and back I found myself opening Nicholas' children's watercolour set. Suddenly it was three days later, and I had painted, it appeared, every angle of Eadly Hall with a shilling children's colour box — and let me tell you these paints do not blend with the ease one might desire! I'm not quite sure what is keeping me at it, yet I do not intend to halt my forward march into speculative art — quite the opposite. In fact I have commandeered the hill near the garden for the express purpose of painting this place from above. Eadly and its looming halls as a small speck in a valley of rolling green, quite the novelty!

There's nothing like being alone to surprise oneself utterly. I do really think that one ought to know who they are, who they truly are, when no one else is present.

There must be a self we can turn to when there is no one around we need care for. So I shall dedicate my solitude to the spirited examination of my own character. And to planning one or two things for the children's return—

after all, Agatha simply cannot turn three without an appropriate to-do!

My fondest love to you and the children, you must tell me all you have been up to.

Yours with affection

Elvira Lockley

THE END

Chessterfield St
Mayfair,
London

Paid 8

Eadly Hall
Milecot
Hobershire

Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milecot
Hobershire



POSTMASTER'S GUIDE

FOR A TWO
PLAYER GAME

for your kind attention

T.P.
Lombard St

Paid 8

Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milecot
Hobershire

T.P.
Piccadilly

Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milecot
Hobershire

Milecot
Hobershire

832

Agatha Lockley
Eadly Hall
Milecot



PLAYING WITH TWO

PLAYING *My Late Father's Correspondence* with two people is a dynamic and emotional experience that adds a new dimension to the game. One player—ideally someone who has already played the game solo—takes on the role of the **Postmaster**, while the other plays the game's central character, **Agatha**.

The Postmaster's role is to facilitate the game, adapting it to the ideas, themes, and choices made by Agatha. Each day, the Postmaster reads Agatha's letters, and uses them as inspiration to shape the next day's correspondence. The Postmaster can send existing letters as they are, modify them to fit the evolving story, or even write entirely new letters from new or existing characters.

Agatha's role is to reply to letters, and in doing so, flesh out Agatha's thoughts, life, and world. Each day, Agatha's player receives the correspondence from the Postmaster, and reads and replies to each letter as usual.

OPTIONAL RULE: AGATHA'S EXTRA LETTER

Optionally, Agatha may write one extra letter per day, to any character already introduced in the game. Agatha can use this to further develop key relationships, start new topics of conversation, or simply express her feelings more fully. This letter is optional and does not need to be sent if no ideas come to mind on that day.

COLLABORATING TOGETHER

During the game, you should feel free to talk “out-of-character” together as needed. For example, you might talk about:

- Letter pacing and scheduling
- Particular ideas, themes, or characters you’d like to explore further
- Themes or ideas you’d prefer not to include in the game
- Additional explanation or context for letters if necessary

PACING YOUR GAME

Before you start, decide together roughly how much time you will need to prepare and respond to each day of correspondence—that is, how many real world days you plan to take to respond to each fictional day of letters. Set an interval that suits both players’ availability and writing pace, whether that’s two days apart or two weeks apart.

While it helps to set rough expectations at the outset, you can adjust your pacing during the game as needed. Note that with two players, *My Late Father’s Correspondence* often takes more letters to complete and it may even take more in-fiction days than the original. Let the game ebb and flow naturally and don’t worry too much about having a set number of letters or days.

FOR THE POSTMASTER ONLY

The rest of this guide is for the Postmaster and contains **major spoilers for the game**. If you intend to be the Postmaster, we highly recommend not reading this section until you've played through the game yourself.

ADAPTING LETTERS FOR YOUR AGATHA

AS POSTMASTER, your role is to adapt and expand the game based on the decisions, themes, and ideas introduced by Agatha. As you play, you will adapt existing letters, and write new letters, and even introduce new characters, to respond to Agatha and immerse yourself in the unique story you are creating. You can do so in the following ways:

1. **Reply to Agatha's questions or comments:**

Alter, adapt, or add letters to reply directly to Agatha's questions or comments.

e.g., Agatha asks her Aunt Gertrude how she met her husband, so you alter Gertrude's next letter to include her nuptial story.

e.g., Agatha asks her Aunt Gertrude to find out more about the painting in the locket, so you create a new letter from the locket's painter explaining its origin (at Aunt Gertrude's request).

2. **Reflect and expand on new information**

introduced by Agatha: Alter, adapt or add letters to bring Agatha's world as she depicts it to life.

e.g., Agatha mentions that her housekeeper quit, so you include a selection of adverts from housekeepers seeking work in the next day of letters.

e.g., Agatha mentions her friend Mary is about to have a baby, so later in the game you create a new letter from Mary updating Agatha with news of the birth.

- 3. Deepen a relationship:** A particular relationship may feel like it needs more time and attention than it is given in the original game. You can deepen the relationship by adding or expanding letters from that character.
- e.g., Agatha strikes up an unexpected friendship with Thomas' mysterious paramour, so you create a new letter where she gives Agatha advice for her future.*
- e.g., It is clear Agatha has a romantic interest in Captain Hughes, so you alter his letter to include some veiled tender sentiments.*

- 4. Explore themes and storylines more fully:**
- As you play, you and your fellow player may find certain themes, storylines, or sets of ideas particularly interesting to explore. You can alter, adapt, or add letters to enjoy this exploration more fully.
- e.g., You and Agatha's player discover through play that Agatha is deeply entrenched in her local community, and in many ways is taking her father's place within it. You decide to create a new letter from the Birdwatching Association, and a new letter from the local town vicar, to bring this theme to life.*
- e.g., Agatha has always wished to know more about her childhood, so you create a new letter written by Nicholas at age 10, which you decide Agatha finds in her father's study.*

Ultimately, the scope of how you can adapt and expand the game for your Agatha is limited only by how much time both players have to devote to the game. That said, while much of the joy of the two player variant is in customising letters, don't feel as if you need to change every single one. A handful of altered or adapted letters, and perhaps one or two new letters, can make the game feel really unique and powerful. The role of Postmaster should be enjoyable, so follow your own fun!



THE POWER OF QUESTIONS

As you adapt or pen new letters to Agatha, don't forget the power of questions. You can ask Agatha direct questions to help her player flesh out more of her life and feelings. You can also give her little conundrums to respond to, like what she should tell her father's military friends about Nicholas's current lifestyle, or even which of her father's periodical subscriptions to cancel.

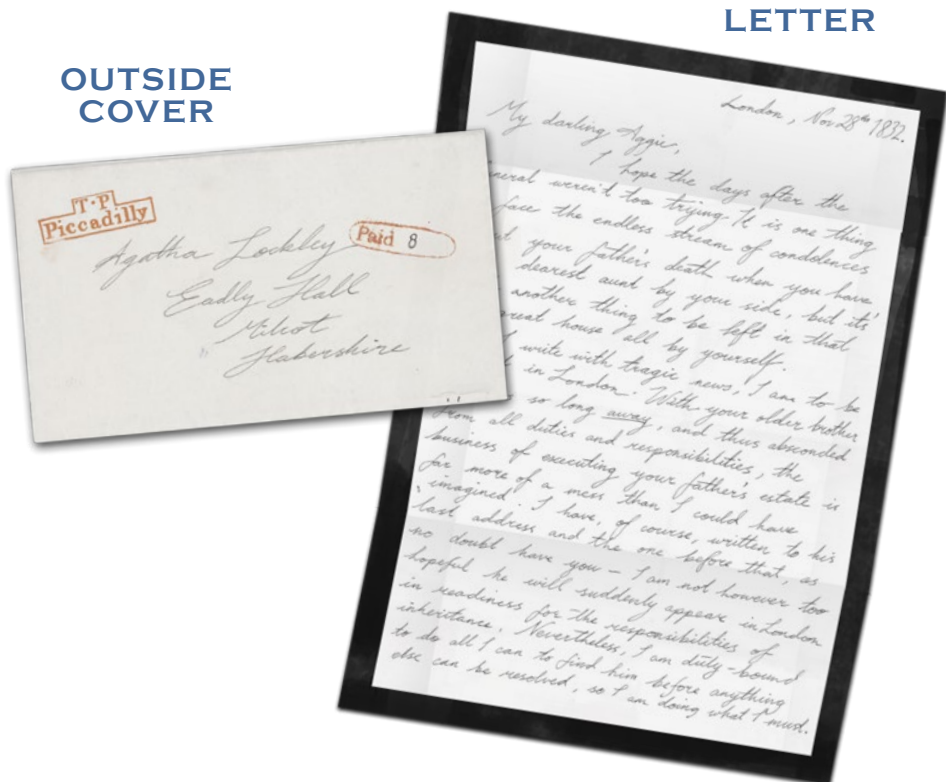
PREPARING YOUR POST

NOW THAT YOU UNDERSTAND the ways you can adapt or create new letters for Agatha, how should you prepare and send them?

The letters in *My Late Father's Correspondence* consist of two parts: the outside of the paper upon which the recipient's name, address, and any postmarks are placed (called the "cover"), and the inside of the paper where the message is written.

INSIDE LETTER

OUTSIDE COVER



Here are three ways you can send letters to Agatha. No matter which you choose, they will be a very exciting experience for Agatha to receive!

- **Send letters in their original format:** If you are not modifying a letter, you can send it to Agatha by exporting the relevant pages from the PDF, or directing Agatha's player to the appropriate pages of the physical book.
- **Send letters typed:** Type your letters out and send them to Agatha either as plain text, or using an evocative handwritten font such as (such as Google Font's 'Ballet' or 'Mea Culpa'). You can use this method to easily modify letters by copying the text from the Plain Text PDF and editing as necessary. You can create or modify the covers in a picture editor, or simply omit the cover entirely.
- **Create letters by hand:** As you create or modify letters, you might find it delightful to pull out your own letter writing set, and pen letters by hand. This will create an even more immersive experience for your Agatha. You can write the cover by hand, or even go the whole way and letterlock the letter as well!

SCHEDULING LETTERS AND DAYS

EARLIER, WE DISCUSSED pacing your days in real-life time. This section is about how to schedule your letters within the fictional days of the game.

Start your thinking by using the original game as a scaffold, keeping letters on the same days as much as possible where it makes sense (editing and adapting them as necessary). Then, think about adding new letters to existing days. From there, you can move letters between days, or if greatly needed, add new days to the game. If you add a new day, you may wish to write an introduction to the day, similar to those found in the book. You may need to move letters between days, or even add days, if:

- A particular letter feels timely or needed in the story earlier than it appears in the game (*e.g. the matter of household staff comes up much earlier so you send letter from the butler and housekeeper on day 3 instead*)
- A particular letter needs to appear at a certain in-fiction time (*e.g. must be after Christmas*)
- A particular letter needs to come before or after certain fictional events (*e.g. you have introduced a suitor for Agatha into your game, and you want him to write to Agatha before Capt. Hughes visits*)
- You find yourself consistently sending three or more letters per day—some of these can instead be grouped into a new day.

SAMPLE SCHEDULE

BELOW IS A SAMPLE SCHEDULE showing how a real Postmastered game unfolded. It shows when the Postmaster adapted existing letters, introduced new letters and characters, and weaved in a little bit of romance in response to Agatha's letters and out-of-character suggestions.

Day 1

- Letter 1A (sent as is)

Day 2

- Letter 2A (sent as is)
- Letter 2B (modified slightly to discuss prospective suitors in line with Agatha's reply from Day 1)

Day 3

- Letter 3A (sent as is)
- Letter 3B (modified slightly to reply to Agatha's last letter to her aunt)

Day 4

- Letter 4A (sent as is)
- A new letter from a new character, in response to Agatha wanting to find out more about the lady in the locket

Day 5

- Letter 4B (modified to reflect the discussion of Agatha's relationship with Rajiv that had occurred so far)
- Letter 5B (as is)

Day 6

- Letter 6A (as is)
- A new letter from the locket painter revealing more information about the mysterious woman

Day 7

- Letter 7B (modified to reflect events in the game so far)
- Letter 5A finally arrives—this time Agatha knows a few things about its writer that she would not want Agatha to know!

Day 8

- Letter 7A (modified to reflect Agatha's prior letter and questions)
- Letter 8A (as is)
- Letter 8B (included all the original material but modified to reflect an optional letter Agatha wrote to Rajiv with a hint of romance, but ultimately it was not to be!)

Day 9

- Letter 9A (modified slightly to reply to Agatha's last letter to her aunt)
- Letter 9B (as is).

EXTENDED EXAMPLES OF ADAPTING LETTERS

**A new paragraph in letter 2B about Mr Alder,
after Agatha mentioned he was troubled:**

I am sad to hear that Mr Alder is suffering so—though I know he has been with you a long time, I was hoping it might be a source of support to you. Perhaps your housekeeper, Mrs Stuart, will have some idea how to snap him out of it, I imagine they know each other very well. Mr Alder ought to find a replacement for the gardener who left also. The condition of roses ought not to be bothering you at such a difficult time! If you don't mind me saying so, darling, you sound a little worse for wear—I hope I can be back earlier than expected.

In this version, the player of Agatha was very interested in her marriage prospects, so I added extra paragraphs to letter 2B:

I can only imagine what it must be like to be there on your own—especially with your father looming so large in Eadly Hall as he did. I am glad Mr Alder is able to bring some comfort. As for Nicholas, there is no need to fear the worst—you know he was always forgetting to stay in touch with your father, more likely than not he's somewhere living in blissful ignorance!

Of course, courting and marriage must wait for you until you are out deep mourning at least (I believe it's two more weeks?), and December in Habershire can be a tad dreary with the snow. But it doesn't hurt to consider one's options. The Habershire Holiday Ball may present some options. Mr Bloom, I believe you know him, and Mr Hastings, newly arrived, may surely prove worthy of a dance at least.

Speaking of gentlemen, I may have found you some company that could do you good. You will never guess who I have run into here in London... [the letter continues on the same from this point].

An altered version of letter 8A, in this version Agatha asked Nicholas to please come back as things are dire—and he actually considered it!

My dear sister,

Merry Christmas, or so it will have been by the time this reaches you. I've been thinking a lot about your last letter. I had a letter from Aunt Gertrude too, so I'm certainly appraised of the situation.

A request from my little sister to come home and deal with things weighs heavily upon me, you know. I don't want you to feel overwhelmed or be too burdened by things without me there. I suppose I'm surprised even to think that you'd believe I would make things better. Things with my partner aren't such that they can come with me, you know how the English can be, terribly prudish about so many things. There is a good reason I prefer it here in Florence.

With all that in mind, I had thought I must ask you one more time whether you'd really like me to return. If you say so, I will book my ticket right now and I will be there before January reaches its end. Then, we shall live as siblings and I can help you until you are sorted with your prospects and secure in your path along life.

The alternative is that I remain here and claim my inheritance in name only, and that things simply keep on going as they are. Aunt knows all the details of all the accounts, send the paperwork to Mr Summers and I shall sign it from here. You can sort it all out with Aunt if you like and I'll simply sign what I am sent, it shall go along swimmingly. Then you can pretty much do as you will with the place for the next however many years, and I shall get on with things here. Write me back as soon as you know, let us be forthright with each other.

Your brother,
Nicholas

**New paragraphs added into Capt. Hughes
first letter 4B, as Agatha wrote him first in this
game using the optional letter:**

Forgive me, I know this is a very serious time with your father's passing so recently behind us, but I must admit your letters quite made me laugh. You've always had a very contrary sense of humour, and I do not believe myself mistaken when I say you still possess it. Of course I remember the argument that heralded our last meeting—we were 16 if I remember rightly, and very serious in our proclamations of each other's future. I would challenge your own admission of my rightness in the matter! But I shall do so in person.

I will arrive on the 10th, as a fan of bird watching although not a fan of galas, it shall be my pleasure to attend with you on the 12th. The Honey Buzzard, unlike its similarly named cousins, is often found in France in the summer—I would wager your father might have seen it there during his campaigns, as would mine. I have not been there myself, as I've been stationed in Gibraltar (where I will return after the winter, all being well.) But I have heard my father tell many stories of the war.

EXTENDED EXAMPLES OF NEW LETTERS

**A letter from a friend, introducing a little
secondary character romance side plot and also
more about Agatha's father's final days:**

Dearest Agatha,

I'm back in Derby, safe and sound, perhaps too safe and sound for I'm to take gentlemen callers right away. I hope you will not blame me for leaving early at my father's request, I know of your many visitors few have stayed long enough to give you comfort. Eadly Hall is truly strange when it is this quiet, and everyone expects your father to be around every corner—even you must have felt it. It was not of my own choosing that I departed—I wish I could have stayed longer—but Mr Hastings and Mr Bloom did come terribly far by visiting from London (a whole day of riding alas how very laborious for them) and so I must be called back from the side of my grieving friend!

It is quite something for them to have arrived together, I am told they are good friends, it is sporting fun, and neither will take it personally were the other to win my hand. Quite ridiculous, exactly the sort of simple minded gentlemen my father would think I should be married to. They seem more or less indistinguishable from each other except that

Mr Hastings is the slightly taller one and Mr Bloom the more glib. I've not yet decided if I should open my mind to their charms or try to close their minds to mine. What do you think I ought to do, should I play the game Agatha?

Ah, but forget about me, how are you holding up? It must be a strange thing indeed for you to be alone at Eadly Hall under such circumstances. I cannot tell if it must be better or worse for you that the whole thing proceeded as expected, that what the doctor said came true, that each day seemed to be predicted by medicine before it happened. The things your father said to you near the end shocked me, that he would say them in front of me as well, although I suppose by then he didn't care. Do you think he really meant them? Do they burden you still?

I am angry about your whole situation, even if you do not seem to be—you are grieving, you are the model grieving child, and yet the world does not seem to be making it easy for you. Your brother too, abandoning everything to leave you with the burden of your father and his passing. I should be there with you to help you face the coming days. Instead I am back here in Derby entertaining various gentlemen—I am going to need some very strong sherry.

Yours in dearest friendship,
Indira Pickford

An alternative letter from Nicholas—in this version of the game Agatha made choices which meant that Nicholas did not know his father had died when he first wrote to Eadly:

Father,

Summers tells me you intend to cut me off. He also told me you have given me far more than I deserve, and also that you are ill and I should be a good son and return to your bedside.

Have you forgotten what it was that we decided? I can only fear you must have for I cannot imagine that you truly wish things to change. Surely you would wish to continue to be thought of as a war hero, or as a hardworking and ambitious man who made his fortune through a judicious sale of his commission—not, by other names that one may call you, were matters to be revealed?

If this has all come about because of some great paranoia about my future, then for your information I have taken up a proper residence here, and my painting is improving rapidly. I have reached a breakthrough in regards to my style, and am likely to even have a chance of showing here in a local galleria soon.

Or perhaps this is your way of trying to call me back to Habershire, because of course you would never bring yourself to simply tell me what you need. If it is, you take a great risk father. I might just decide to never darken your doorstep again.

**Agatha's romance with Capt. Hughes slowly brewed
and resolved on the final day with this extra letter:**

Dear Agatha,

I am afraid I cannot stomach to begin this with polite conversation, you must have already guessed the questions that compelled me to write this letter. During Christmas, certainly we had both had a little claret (or perhaps a bit more than a little), and there was that general feeling of cheer and possibility that accompanies a holiday celebrated with sweet cakes and copious gifts. In that evening I had come to imagine, be it through the words you said, the way you looked at me, and the general manner of your bearing, that there might indeed be something between us. A feeling that I had thought inevitably ebbed away with time may still dwell within us (yes I know well what you thought then, whether you said it or not!).

I counseled myself not to write, it is ill form to pressure a lady. However, I have had no sleep over it and I am compelled to pen this letter lest the feelings I saw that night lock themselves away again within us with no recourse. So tell me now whether I am indulging something I have simply imagined or would do best to ignore, or whether, in the sober light of today's snow, there might still be something worth talking about.

I hope you will forgive me, but some things are worth breaking form for.

Yours in fondest hope,
Rajiv Hughes

**We hope you enjoyed your first
Read & Reply game!**

Join us next time for a MURDER MYSTERY in
outback Australia, and a court trial fought against the odds.



DEAR SISTER, I am in desperate need of your wise advice. It is about what we had witnessed, at the Althams, you know of what I write.

The disagreements between John and Mr Altham about the cattle are so much worse now, and he has been pushing me to come forward with it. He says my conscience demands I tell, though it is so clear he cares only for revenge.

It is queer, a secret everyone told us we must keep, that we have held like a precious egg clutched to our chest lest it break, and now John says I must go to the police directly.

I would dismiss him with ease, but the worst part is, I fear he is right. My conscience is screaming day and night. Do I not owe it to that tender soul to revoke my vow of silence? To Langley? To even the world?

What ought I to do?



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Habershire, 1832. When her father passes away after a long and lingering illness, Agatha Lockley is alone in her childhood home of Eadly Hall. Eadly's heir, her older brother Nicholas, is nowhere to be found, and she is left to manage the future of the estate and the heavy weight of grief. As she sorts through the effects of a distant father, letters old and new reveal family secrets and hidden memories. With the floodgates of the past now open, what will she choose for her future?

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